

Commentary

Reflection on the University and the Academic as “Critic and Conscience of Society”

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On the origin of the phrase: some historical background

During my term of office as Chairperson of the Department of Education at Victoria University of Wellington, New Zealand, I received a memorandum from the Dean of Arts, Professor Gary Hawke, asking me if I could provide him with a list of the essential defining characteristics of a university. This was in the latter part of 1988.

I supplied him with, what might be called, a conventional wisdom definition including such features as:

- to be a repository of knowledge and expertise in society,
- to advance by scholarship and research the boundaries of existing knowledge,
- to be a source of impartial and comprehensive knowledge,
- to encourage intellectual inquiry, independence and autonomous thinking,
- to publish scholarly and scientific papers, journals and academic books which meet international standards of quality,
- to provide advanced forms of teaching for students based upon the latest developments in knowledge and research.

Upon further reflection, I added:

- to accept a role as critic and conscience of society.

I added this final characteristic because I wanted to emphasise that universities in free and democratic societies have a crucial “balance of power role” in relation to whatever political party or political ideology is currently in power. A university, in other words has a responsibility “to speak truth to power”, where this “truth” is based upon systematic and impartial analysis, scholarship and empirical research. As modern governments command more and more power, often via their influence over various forms of mass media, the universities exist as an independent check upon what governments say is the truth. This at least, has been the theory of what

universities should do as theories about the university as an institution have developed since the time of J.H. Newman's classic statement, *The Idea of a University* (1852,1976). What was a concern for me was that there appeared to be evidence (especially visible in the UK in the 1980s) that universities were in danger of losing that role as they became more and more dependent upon government money and research funds. In other words, the colonisation of universities by powerful political and ideological interests appeared to be in process and therefore it was necessary to state explicitly that an authentic university had to be "a critic and conscience of society".

I was naturally very pleased to see when Gary Hawke's report, *Learning for Life* was published in February 1989, that this key phrase was included (p. 24) and subsequently was enshrined in New Zealand legislation as part of the defining characteristics of a university. This confirmed for me that New Zealand was determined to maintain its proud tradition of intellectual and democratic independence, whatever the rest of the world might be doing.

Response to Hattie

Given this historical background, I was interested to read this article in a recent edition of NZJES. I was pleased to see that the language of "critic and conscience of society" was still being used in public debates about education in New Zealand. In this commentary, I wish to make a personal response to John Hattie's call that: "There needs to be a renewed debate about the role of academics in public fora, in policy commentary, and how best they are to deserve their place among the "critics and conscience of society" (p. 94).

What I want to suggest in my contribution to the debate is that Professor Hattie has misunderstood the role of the academic as a critic and conscience of society. What a reading of both his book, *Visible Learning: A Synthesis Of 800+ Meta-Analyses on Achievement* (2009) and of his article (2010) shows is that he has made a major contribution to the scholarship of assessment, teaching and learning which has questioned the preoccupation of other scholars with structural matters "such as grouping or class size" while ignoring (relatively) "the enormous power of quality teaching" (p. 86). This is a perfectly reasonable and well-evidenced contribution to contemporary debates about the relative importance of structural as opposed to pedagogical determinants of educational achievement. However, the role that Professor Hattie has performed in this work is not that of critic and conscience of society but rather that of critic of the quality of research and assumptions in the academic field, assessment, teaching and learning. It is in that sense, part of the normal technical and critical academic work expected of professors of education. However, John Hattie has chosen to focus his analysis on matters largely internal to the educational system. As he expresses it:-

I realised that many sociologists would not be pleased that non-school factors were not placed at the forefront of all claims, but I noted that this was "not because they are unimportant, indeed they may be more important than many of the issues discussed in this book. It is just that I have not included these topics in my orbit. (pp. x-xi)

Now this is not a statement which could reasonably be made by an academic adopting the role of critic and conscience of society because what Professor Hattie refers to as “non-school factors” represents society. These non-school factors include the existing structural distribution of life chances for children and young people as mediated by the cultural, social and economic conditions of their homes and communities. Their omission, apart from one chapter, from a major work on the determinants of educational achievement is all the more surprising when the author admits that “they may be more important than many of the issues discussed in this book” (pp. viii-ix).

The education academic in the role of critic and conscience of society has an obligation to include non-school factors in all analyses of differential educational achievement because otherwise both politicians and citizens are encouraged to believe that changes in educational arrangements alone can solve much of the existing inequalities in educational achievements. This reductionist and naive view of the influence of schooling alone in determining educational achievements is very convenient for politicians and policy makers because it diverts attention away from more fundamental questions about social and economic inequalities in society and their role in affecting educational outcomes. It was brilliantly critiqued by Professor Basil Bernstein in his classic essay, *Education Cannot Compensate for Society* (1970), where he pointed out to politicians, policy makers and to “society”, that improvements in teaching and learning could only do so much but without serious external structural and economic reforms, schools could not create equality of educational opportunity by themselves.

In this role, Bernstein was acting as a critic and conscience of society: that is, he drew attention to the crucial importance of non-school factors. In New Zealand, the late Roy Nash was a scholar in this tradition, with his masterly analysis of *Social Class and Education in New Zealand* (2003). Roy was a critic and conscience of society because his detailed work on differential educational achievement was always permeated by a clear awareness that non-school factors were central to an understanding of the problem and to a realistic set of political and policy initiatives to begin to deal with it.

My hope is that the universities and academics of New Zealand will continue to maintain the crucial role of being critic and conscience of society in the contemporary challenges of globalisation and of its consequences.

It would be a great contribution to this end if Professor Hattie would now write a sequel to his earlier book by addressing in detail the role of non-school factors and their influence upon educational achievement. In doing so he would make a legitimate claim to being a critic and conscience of society.

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